

wolf spider (MM 330) ([PICTURE](#)) lay in wait on the bridge's underbelly. Thin strands of nearly invisible webbing coating the bridge alerts the spiders to any movement on top. The spiders instinctively attack anything that disturbs their webs, but flee if taken below half their health points.

A Wisdom (Perception) check DC 15 notices the thin webbing on the bridge. An Intelligence (Nature) check DC 10 confirms the webbing to belong to giant spiders. Taking a peek under the bridge (hopefully not too close!) can spot the spiders lurking in the shadows with a Wisdom (Perception) check DC 20.

Webs. Thin webs cover the surface of the bridge. The squares are difficult terrain, and a creature trying to move through them must succeed on a DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check. On a failure, the creature is restrained in the webs. A snared creature can take an action each round to attempt to break free with a DC 12 Strength check, or it can try to cut its way free by using a light weapon that deals slashing damage. The webs have AC 10, 5 hit points, vulnerability to fire damage, and immunity to bludgeoning, poison, and psychic damage.

DEVELOPMENTS

Characters can choose to avoid the bridge and spiders entirely and navigate down into the ravine and back up the other side, adding several hours to their journey. It takes a Strength (Athletics) check DC 10 to climb up or down the ravine walls.

TREASURE

Three web cocoons are stuck on the bridge's underside. Adventurers looking under the bridge can notice the cocoons tucked into shallow pits with a Wisdom (Perception) check DC 20. Reaching the cocoons is another challenge altogether. If they come up with a way to do so and loot the dessicated corpses, they'll find 30 cp, 27 sp, and 8 gp in coins, emerald-encrusted earrings and a gold necklace with a tear-shaped ruby together worth 30 gp total, and a *potion of healing*.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 250 XP equally among the characters if the party defeats the giant spiders or goes around them.

WOLF IN SHEEP'S CLOTHING

The party arrives at a roadside shrine. Before, these shrines provided travellers a safe haven, its protective magics warding the immediate area from evil creatures. But with the archangel Avacyn's disappearance, the holy magic of the shrine has gone dormant.

The jagged stone road curves around a stony peak. As you round the bend, you see an alcove in the mountainside. In the middle of the alcove, bursting through the rocky ground, is a wide pine tree stump. Carved from what used to be its trunk and rising up from its stump is the symbol of the Church: Avacyn's Collar. Wild flowers, wooden trinkets, and prayer beads adorn the shrine.

Kneeling in prayer in front of the shrine is a pale sweaty human wearing dirty, torn shepherd's clothing.

The praying man is Anton Wepper ([PICTURE](#)), a shepherd from the village Lammas. Anton carries a dark secret: a few nights ago he was bitten by a **werewolf** and cursed with **lycanthropy** (MM 206). Fearing for the safety of his loved ones, he left his home and is making the trek to Shadowgrange, hoping to pick up supplies there and then continue on to the farbog to live in isolation. Anton has been praying ceaselessly to Avacyn hoping not to let the curse take hold, but unknown to him, tomorrow night is a full moon, which will cause him to involuntarily transform into a werewolf.

Anton is initially fearful of the PCs but can be calmed down if they prove they aren't vampires or other monsters. If Anton finds out that they're going to Shadowgrange, he begs to come along, as the road is dangerous. He tells them that he's stopping by Shadowgrange to start a new life, which is vague but true. If pressed about his motives, he lies, saying that he inherited land near Shadowgrange and he is traveling to sign papers. He's also willing to provide any local knowledge about Stensia, basic information about important locations, rumors, dangers on the road, and other bits of local knowledge.

A Wisdom (Insight) check DC 13 can notice that the nervous shepherd is withholding information. A Wisdom (Perception) check DC 15 notices a burn mark in the shape of Avacyn's Collar on his wrist (Anton hides it under his sleeve). An Intelligence (Religion) check DC 13 confirms that the signs point to lycanthropy. An Intelligence (Nature) check DC 13 confirms the next full moon for tomorrow night. Getting Anton to speak truly about his curse can be done through diplomacy, intimidation, and other methods.

DEVELOPMENTS

The shrine's divine magic lays dormant. A character can spend an hour performing the proper holy rituals with an Intelligence (Religion) check DC 15 to reactivate the divine magic. Doing so grants anyone resting at the shrine an Inspiration Point, and evil creatures are compelled not to approach the shrine's immediate vicinity.

Anton is a good man but afraid to die. If the party figures out his curse, he begs them to help, swearing that he is faithful to Avacyn and doesn't want to hurt anyone. He

needs them to escort him to Shadowgrange where he can pick up supplies and escape north into the swamps, away from human civilization.

If he feels his life is threatened, Anton will make a desperate attempt to defend himself. He is a **commoner** (MM 345) with a light crossbow.

The next night, when the full moon rises, he transforms into a **werewolf** (MM 211), losing all self-control and goes on a murderous rampage.

TREASURE

Anton carries a small sack of coins holding 15 cp, 4 sp, and 1 gp. In the shepherd's coat pocket is his most treasured possession, an *avacyn collar* (APPENDIX A) (L). Anton can no longer wear it as *blessed silver* burns his flesh. If the characters agree to let him travel with them, he gives them the chain as thanks before parting ways.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 300 XP equally among the characters once they've dealt with Anton any way they choose. In the event that they defeat him once he's transformed into a werewolf, instead divide 600 XP.

CONCLUSION OF PART 1

On the end of the third day of travel, the party arrives at Shadowgrange, where the adventure continues in part 2.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Reaching the village of Shadowgrange completes a story milestone. Divide 300 XP equally among the characters. This should provide enough XP for the characters to attain 2nd level.

MILESTONE: LEVEL 2!

If you are using Milestone Experience, then the characters attain 2nd level once they reach Shadowgrange.





PART 2: SHADOWGRANGE

Shadowgrange ([MAP](#)) is one of the oldest human settlements in Stensia. Most of the villagers are farmers, the majority being shepherds. The rest of the villagers work in trades that support the farmers by spinning wool, weaving clothes, shoeing horses, milling grain, and the like. Some merchants move goods from Shadowgrange to other settlements such as Lammas, but shipments move less frequently these days as the roads become more dangerous.

In the last two years, Shadowgrange has experienced a swell of new citizens that sought refuge behind the village's fortifications. Most of these folk come from smaller remote villages that have been destroyed by over-indulgent vampires, mindless undead, or sadistic ghoullers. With Avacyn's presence missing from the land, the protective holy wards of these villages are failing, and creatures of the night are making bolder attacks. Shadowgrange's moat and stone walls make it one of the best defended villages in the area, but many villagers secretly believe that this settlement will eventually fall just like the rest.

When characters first arrive in Shadowgrange, read or paraphrase:

The valley dips downward and you see dozens of sheep flocks roaming the thin, wispy hills, with shepherds watching over them. Beyond, nestled in a corner beside the jagged mountain range, is Shadowgrange. The dirt path swings around farms and wooden cottages until it reaches the village's moat, where sheep gather round for

a drink. Beyond the drawbridge over the water stands an iron-reinforced wooden gate flanked by two guards, the only way through Shadowgrange's stone walls. A small grove of hawthorn trees grows near the moat and more branches can be seen poking over the village walls.

2 guards (MM 347), twin brothers Lars and Sven, stand watch outside of the village gates. These cathars hail the adventurers as they approach over the drawbridge. In a cold formal tone, they check to see if the characters are fiends by asking them to give them the palm of their hand, which they touch with an *avacyn collar* made of *blessed silver* (APPENDIX A).

Once satisfied that the characters aren't supernatural abominations, the guards, Lars animates dramatically, tossing aside his formal speech and tries to chum it up with the newcomers, much to the bemoaning of Sven, who deems this "unprofessional." Lars is a lighthearted and curious fellow, rarely seeing strangers in the area, and the adventurers intrigue him. The twins are willing to provide local knowledge to the characters and point them in the direction of wherever they need to go.

ENCOUNTERS IN SHADOWGRANGE

The party will probably want to freshen up after their long journey to Shadowgrange. They can rest at the inn, restock their supplies at the general shop, acquire new weapons at the blacksmith, and receive divine blessings at the village church. The party's goals will then lead them to one or more of the following locations:

Haunted House. All adventure hooks involving Katarina Brunn or the holy relic lead to the haunted house of the former mayor. Villagers questioned about these things direct the PCs to Priestess Flora at the chapel where they can get more information.

Alchemist's Shop. Siegfried's alchemy shop has been abandoned ever since he left Shadowgrange. The villagers are concerned about Siegfried's disappearance, and that the hawthorn tree growing in the center of the shop is mysteriously dying. Any inquiries about the shop are directed to Captain Levi at the visgaud grounds.

Saint Traft's Memorial. Inside Shadowgrange's chapel is a statue commemorating the local saint, Traft. One of the greatest cathars to have ever lived, it's said that his spirit occasionally bestows blessings on worthy visitors. Characters making pilgrimage to Traft's memorial will be pointed here.

IMPORTANT NPCs

Here is a quick summary of the most important NPCs in Shadowgrange, and their relevance to the adventure.

Eckhardt Sheck	Innkeeper
Magda Botler	Owns a trading post; secretly a Skirsdag cultist; has a cursed item for the party
Flora Mayweather	Head priestess of Shadowgrange's chapel; has a quest for the party
Marcus Ritter	Blacksmith; has a quest for the party
Silvia Wintsch	Fletcher; has a quest for the party
Captain Levi	Captain of the local militia; has a quest for the party

ROLEPLAYING SHADOWGRANGE NPCs

The humans of Shadowgrange are stoic folk, neither expressive nor demonstrative people. Countless generations of hardship and proximity to the vampire strongholds – lost children, lost neighbors – have taught them to guard their hearts. They are proud and fervent in their beliefs but seem brusque or even cold to outsiders.

Times have been particularly rough these past few seasons with the disappearance of Avacyn. The holy wards protecting humanity are losing power, and the villagers are becoming more paranoid and fearful as attacks from creatures of the night become bolder and more frequent. Shadowgrange is becoming more crowded as they take in refugees from neighboring villages that have fallen to darkness, and the stress of accommodating more people to protect and mouths to feed is worsening their tempers.

Spirits are at an all-time low with the murder of the mayor four months ago. The villagers stood frozen in fear as Voldaren vampires strolled into their village, murdered their mayor, and kidnapped Katarina (See “Background”). That event really drove home the knowledge that the people of Shadowgrange are truly helpless in the face of the horrors around them. Fear and shame have kept them from even clearing out the mayor's haunted house.

People feel a little resentment towards Thraben, the seat of the Avacynian Church. They believe the high priesthood isn't doing enough to protect Stensians, instead getting wealthy off tithes and living in safety behind Thraben's walls while places like Shadowgrange suffer.

Martial and magical prowess is highly prized in humanity's fight for survival. Villagers are initially wary of the characters but the adventurers quickly earn their respect and admiration if they prove to be protecting them -- clearing the haunted house, for example. Gruff “off you go then” goodbyes turn into “Avacyn's blessings upon you, heroes.”

TOWN DESCRIPTION

Most of the villagers live on their farms outside of Shadowgrange's walls. The tradesfolk and wealthier citizens live inside. Each cottage is built around a hawthorn tree, with the tree's trunk in the center of the common room and its branches poke above the rooftop. This provides residents centralized access to living wood (APPENDIX A) as a defense against vampires. Every cottage also features a mirror on the outside of the front door to dissuade vampires from approaching, and often have prayers to Avacyn engraved on the door frame to repel evil spirits.

The following section detail specific locations in town.

SILVER ROSE INN

Silver Rose Inn is a popular destination in the evening for villagers taking a break after a long day's work. Most folk head back home before nightfall, however, as the roads are far more dangerous once the sun goes down.

There are eight rooms available for rent. If the characters decide to stay here, see “Food, Drink, and Lodging” in the *Player's Handbook* for pricing (PHB 158).

The innkeeper, Eckhardt Sheck, is a former cathar (statted as a Neutral Good **thug** [MM 350]). Although in his mid 50's with thin greying blonde hair, he remains an imposing figure; his thick, muscled, hairy arms look like they could snap a regular man in two, or at least they could if he had a right hand instead of a grasping hook -- he lost it fighting off a swarm of ghouls, nasty business. His permanent scowl and gruff attitude hides his kind heart.

If asked about Katarina Brunn, the artifact from the Avacynian Church, or Saint Traft's memorial, Eckhardt tells them to speak with priestess Flora at the village church, saying that she would know more about those things than anyone else.

Rumors. Spending a little time in the common room and chatting up the townspeople can provide the characters with a number of good leads to explore around the village. NPCs present in the Silver Rose Inn and the rumors they pass on include:

- Gerold, an old farmer: “Priestess Flora is still looking for tough folks to try and purge the spirits in the old mayor's house.”
- Lena, a shepherd: “The hawthorne tree the alchemist shop is built around looks to be dying. Someone needs to check out what's killing it.”
- Merle, a cathar: “I placed an order for a blessed silver longsword months ago. Marcus, the blacksmith, says there's a shortage though.”
- Carsten, a priest: “Last week I prayed at Saint Traft's memorial in the chapel, and I swear by Avacyn's Light,